

# CHAPTER 1

## INTRODUCTION: THE CLASSICAL–FOLK DIVIDE IN INDIAN MUSIC

### 1.1 Introduction

Music has been an important part of Indian culture for thousands of years. From religious rituals and devotional practices to social gatherings and artistic performances, music has played a significant role in shaping cultural identity. Over time, Indian music developed into a number of traditions, among which classical and folk music emerged as two major streams. Although these traditions are often discussed separately, they have continuously interacted with each other throughout history.

Hindustani classical music is generally understood as a highly organised system based on ragas and talas. Its performance practice follows established musical principles that have evolved over centuries. Bengali folk music, on the other hand, developed largely through oral transmission and community participation. It is closely connected to everyday life, local customs, religious beliefs and regional experiences. Despite these differences, many Bengali folk melodies display musical features that appear similar to those found in classical ragas.

This observation raises an important question. Are these similarities the result of direct influence from classical music, or do they reflect older melodic traditions that developed independently? The present study seeks to explore this question through a theoretical analysis of selected Bengali folk genres.

### 1.2 Background of the Study

The relationship between folk music and classical music has been discussed by musicians and scholars for a long time. Some researchers believe that folk traditions preserve ancient melodic practices that existed before the formal codification of ragas. Others argue that the spread of classical music gradually influenced regional musical cultures, leading to similarities between folk melodies and ragas.

In Bengal, this discussion becomes particularly interesting. The region possesses a rich variety of folk traditions, each shaped by unique social and geographical conditions. The songs of the boatmen along the rivers, the mystical songs of the Bauls, the emotional expressions of Bhawaiya singers and the devotional melodies of Kirtan performers all demonstrate distinctive

musical identities. At the same time, listeners often recognise melodic patterns that resemble ragas such as Kafi, Bhairavi, Pilu and Khamaj.

The existence of these similarities does not automatically prove a direct relationship. A melody may share a scale with a raga while functioning in a completely different musical manner. Therefore, a detailed analytical approach is necessary.

### **1.3 Statement of the Problem**

Although Bengali folk music has been widely studied from historical, cultural and literary perspectives, fewer studies have focused on its modal and melodic structures in relation to raga theory. In many discussions, folk songs are simply labelled as being “based on” particular ragas without a detailed examination of their actual melodic behaviour.

As a result, there remains a need for a systematic study that compares folk melodies with classical raga structures and evaluates the extent to which such comparisons are musically justified.

### **1.4 Research Questions**

The study is guided by the following questions:

1. Do selected Bengali folk melodies follow the grammatical principles of Hindustani ragas?
2. To what extent do folk melodies resemble established raga structures?
3. Can similarities between folk music and ragas be explained solely through classical influence?
4. Is it possible to propose a separate theoretical framework for analysing Bengali folk modal structures?

### **1.5 Objectives of the Study**

The main objectives of this study are:

- To examine the melodic structures of selected Bengali folk songs.
- To compare these structures with recognised Hindustani ragas.
- To identify similarities and differences between folk modality and raga grammar.
- To explore the historical and theoretical relationship between folk music and classical music.
- To propose a framework for understanding Bengali folk modal systems.

## 1.6 Scope of the Study

The present study focuses on four important Bengali folk traditions:

- Baul
- Bhatiali
- Bhawaiya
- Kirtan

The analysis is limited to melodic and modal characteristics. Rhythmic analysis, lyrical interpretation and sociological discussion are included only when they contribute directly to the understanding of melodic structure.

## 1.7 Significance of the Study

This study contributes to the growing field of Indian musicology by addressing an area that has received comparatively less attention. Rather than viewing folk music merely as a source of cultural heritage, the research examines it as a sophisticated musical system deserving independent theoretical consideration.

The study may also be useful for performers, teachers and students who wish to understand the relationship between Bengali folk traditions and Hindustani classical music in greater depth.

## 1.8 Methodology

The research follows an analytical and comparative approach.

The methodology includes:

- Study of relevant books, journals and research publications.
- Selection of representative songs from Baul, Bhatiali, Bhawaiya and Kirtan traditions.
- Transcription of melodic passages using Bhatkhande notation.
- Comparison of folk melodic structures with established raga frameworks.
- Analysis of scales, note emphasis, phrase movement and melodic behaviour.

The study relies primarily on documented musical sources and published scholarship.

## **1.9 Chapter Outline**

Chapter One introduces the research topic, objectives, methodology and scope of the study.

Chapter Two reviews major literature related to raga theory, folk music studies and Indian musicology.

Chapter Three discusses the historical background and melodic characteristics of selected Bengali folk genres.

Chapter Four develops the analytical framework used for comparing folk melodies and ragas.

Chapter Five presents detailed case studies and musical analyses.

Chapter Six proposes a theoretical model for Bengali folk modal structures and summarises the findings of the research.

## **1.10 Conclusion**

The relationship between Bengali folk music and Hindustani classical music remains a complex and fascinating subject. While similarities between the two traditions are often recognised, the precise nature of their connection requires careful musical analysis rather than simple assumptions. The following chapters attempt to investigate this relationship through a detailed examination of selected folk genres and their melodic structures.

## CHAPTER 2

### LITERATURE REVIEW: RAGA THEORY, FOLK MUSICOLOGY AND THE STUDY OF BENGALI FOLK MUSIC

#### 2.1 Introduction

The relationship between Bengali folk music and Hindustani classical music has attracted the attention of musicians, scholars and researchers for many decades. Although both traditions have been studied extensively, they have often been examined separately. Classical music studies generally focus on raga theory, performance practice and historical development, while folk music research tends to emphasise cultural identity, social history and oral tradition. As a result, comparatively fewer studies have investigated the modal relationship between Bengali folk melodies and classical ragas through detailed musical analysis.

The purpose of this chapter is to examine the major scholarly contributions relevant to the present research. Particular attention is given to writings on Indian music theory, raga development, folk music studies and Bengali musical traditions. The chapter also identifies important gaps in existing scholarship that justify the need for the present study.

#### 2.2 Early Foundations of Indian Music Theory

The theoretical foundations of Indian music can be traced to ancient Sanskrit treatises. Among these works, Bharata's *Natyashastra* occupies a position of exceptional importance. Although the text primarily addresses drama, dance and performance, it also contains detailed discussions of musical concepts such as *swaras*, scales and melodic organisation.

The *Natyashastra* does not describe ragas in the modern sense. Nevertheless, it demonstrates that Indian scholars had already begun to analyse musical structures systematically. Many of the concepts discussed by Bharata later influenced the development of more sophisticated musical theories.

Several scholars have observed that the *Natyashastra* represents a stage in which musical thought was still evolving from earlier modal practices toward more specialised melodic systems. This observation is particularly relevant to the present study because it suggests that Indian music has always existed within a dynamic process of development rather than within a fixed theoretical framework.

The importance of the *Natyashastra* therefore lies not only in its historical value but also in its demonstration that theory and practice have continuously influenced one another throughout the history of Indian music.

### **2.3 Matanga and the Emergence of the Raga Concept**

A major development occurred with Matanga's *Brihaddeshi*, which is often regarded as one of the earliest texts to discuss the concept of raga in a recognisable form.

Matanga described raga as a melodic entity capable of producing aesthetic pleasure through specific note combinations and characteristic movements. This definition marked an important shift in musical thinking. Instead of focusing solely on scales or note collections, attention began to move toward the expressive and structural behaviour of melodies.

Many modern scholars regard the *Brihaddeshi* as a bridge between earlier modal systems and the mature raga traditions that developed later. The text demonstrates that the concept of raga emerged gradually through a process of musical experimentation and theoretical refinement.

For the present study, Matanga's contribution is particularly important because it highlights the distinction between a simple scale and a fully developed melodic structure. This distinction remains central to the comparison between folk melodies and classical ragas.

### **2.4 Sharngadeva and the Expansion of Musical Theory**

The *Sangeeta Ratnakara* of Sharngadeva occupies a unique position within Indian musicology because it serves as a link between ancient and medieval musical traditions.

The text discusses swaras, melodic structures, rhythm, performance practice and aesthetic principles in considerable detail. Many later developments in both Hindustani and Carnatic music can be traced to ideas found within this work.

Unlike earlier texts, the *Sangeeta Ratnakara* demonstrates a growing concern with classification and organisation. Sharngadeva attempted to explain musical behaviour through systematic analysis, thereby contributing to the development of music as an academic discipline.

Researchers continue to regard this text as one of the most important sources for understanding the historical evolution of Indian music. At the same time, scholars acknowledge that musical practice has continued to evolve beyond the frameworks described by Sharngadeva.

This observation reminds us that theoretical systems, however influential, do not fully determine musical behaviour. Folk traditions in particular often preserve practices that exist outside formal theoretical classifications.

## **2.5 Bhatkhande and Modern Raga Classification**

No discussion of Hindustani music theory can overlook the contributions of Vishnu Narayan Bhatkhande. During the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries, Bhatkhande undertook extensive efforts to document and classify musical knowledge from different gharanas and performance traditions.

His most widely recognised contribution is the *thaat* system, which organises ragas according to scalar structure. The system remains one of the most influential pedagogical tools in Hindustani music education.

However, scholars have also pointed out certain limitations of the *thaat* system. While it provides a useful method for classification, it does not fully explain the identity of many ragas. Important features such as phrase structure, note emphasis and performance practice often extend beyond simple scale relationships.

This criticism becomes particularly relevant when analysing folk music. If even classical ragas cannot be understood solely through scale structure, then folk melodies certainly require a broader analytical approach.

The present study therefore adopts Bhatkhande's notation system while recognising that scale analysis alone cannot adequately explain modal behaviour.

## **2.6 Folk Music in Musicological Research**

For much of the twentieth century, academic discussions of Indian music focused primarily on classical traditions. Folk music was frequently studied from anthropological, cultural or sociological perspectives rather than as a sophisticated musical system.

Over time, this situation began to change. Researchers increasingly recognised that folk traditions preserve valuable information about regional musical practices, historical development and cultural identity.

One important debate concerns the relationship between folk and classical traditions. Some scholars argue that folk music preserves ancient modal structures that existed before the

codification of ragas. Others suggest that classical music gradually influenced regional traditions through religious institutions, court patronage and educational systems.

Neither perspective fully explains the complexity of musical exchange in South Asia. Increasingly, researchers have begun to view folk and classical traditions as interacting systems that influence one another continuously.

This more balanced perspective provides an important foundation for the present study.

## **2.7 Scholarship on Bengali Folk Music**

Research on Bengali folk music has expanded considerably during the last century. Scholars have examined the historical, cultural and religious dimensions of genres such as Baul, Bhatiali, Bhawaiya and Kirtan.

Studies of Baul music often focus on spirituality, philosophy and the teachings associated with figures such as Lalon Fakir. These investigations have contributed significantly to our understanding of Baul thought and cultural identity.

Research on Bhatiali has emphasised its connection with river culture and the occupational life of boatmen. Scholars have frequently highlighted the importance of landscape in shaping the emotional and musical character of the genre.

Similarly, studies of Bhawaiya have explored regional identity, emotional expression and vocal style, while research on Kirtan has focused largely on devotional practice and the influence of the Vaishnava movement.

Although these studies provide valuable cultural insights, relatively few of them examine melodic structures in a systematic analytical manner. In many cases, observations regarding raga influence remain descriptive rather than analytical.

## **2.8 Research Gap**

The literature reviewed above reveals a significant gap in existing scholarship.

Classical music studies provide detailed explanations of raga theory but rarely examine Bengali folk traditions in depth. Conversely, folk music studies often discuss cultural and historical issues without undertaking detailed modal analysis.

As a result, the precise relationship between Bengali folk melodies and Hindustani ragas remains insufficiently explored.

Many writers acknowledge similarities between folk songs and ragas, yet relatively few attempt to analyse these similarities through direct comparison of scales, phrase structures, note emphasis and melodic behaviour.

The present research seeks to address this gap by combining insights from musicology, folk studies and modal analysis.

## **2.9 Relevance of the Present Study**

The significance of the present research lies in its attempt to bridge two areas of scholarship that are often treated separately. By examining folk melodies through a structured analytical framework, the study contributes to a deeper understanding of both Bengali folk traditions and Indian modal systems.

Rather than assuming that folk songs are simply derived from classical ragas, the research investigates the relationship critically and evaluates similarities and differences on musical grounds.

This approach allows a more balanced interpretation of the interaction between folk and classical traditions.

## **2.10 Conclusion**

The literature reviewed in this chapter demonstrates that both raga theory and Bengali folk music possess rich intellectual traditions supported by extensive scholarship. However, the relationship between these two areas remains incompletely understood.

While previous researchers have provided valuable historical, cultural and theoretical insights, comparatively few studies have undertaken detailed modal comparison between Bengali folk melodies and Hindustani ragas. This gap provides the primary justification for the present research.

The following chapter examines the selected folk genres in greater detail and discusses their historical background as well as their melodic characteristics.

## CHAPTER 3

### SELECTED FOLK GENRES AND THEIR MELODIC CHARACTERISTICS

#### 3.1 Introduction

Bengali folk music represents one of the richest musical traditions of the Indian subcontinent. Developed over centuries through oral transmission, these traditions reflect the cultural, geographical and social experiences of the people who created and preserved them. Unlike Hindustani classical music, which gradually evolved through theoretical codification and formal training systems, folk music emerged naturally within local communities and became closely connected with everyday life.

Although Bengali folk music is often discussed as a single category, it actually consists of several distinct genres, each possessing its own history, performance practice and melodic character. The present study focuses on four important traditions: Baul, Bhatiali, Bhawaiya and Kirtan. These genres have been selected because they occupy significant positions within Bengali musical culture and because they provide valuable material for examining relationships between folk modality and classical raga structures.

The purpose of this chapter is to introduce the historical background and melodic characteristics of these genres before undertaking detailed modal analysis in the following chapters.

#### 3.2 Baul Music

Among the many folk traditions of Bengal, Baul music occupies a unique position because of its strong connection with spirituality and philosophical thought. The Bauls are wandering mystic singers who seek spiritual truth through personal experience rather than strict adherence to institutional religious practices. Their philosophy draws influences from Vaishnavism, Sufism and various indigenous spiritual traditions, creating a distinctive worldview that is reflected in their songs.

The lyrics of Baul songs often explore themes such as the search for the divine within the human body, the nature of existence and the relationship between the individual and the universe. As a result, music functions not merely as entertainment but as a medium for spiritual expression and communication.

From a musical perspective, Baul songs are generally characterised by melodic simplicity combined with expressive flexibility. The melodies often revolve around a limited number of notes and short recurring phrases. However, within this apparent simplicity, performers introduce subtle variations in ornamentation, rhythm and phrase structure. The result is a musical style that feels spontaneous and deeply personal.

Many Baul melodies display modal characteristics that resemble ragas such as Pilu, Kafi and Bhairavi. Certain note combinations and phrase movements create similarities with these classical structures. Nevertheless, Baul music does not usually follow the strict grammatical framework associated with raga performance. The primary concern of the performer remains emotional and spiritual communication rather than the preservation of raga identity.

This combination of modal familiarity and structural freedom makes Baul music particularly relevant to the present study.

### **3.3 Bhatiali Music**

Bhatiali is one of the most widely recognised forms of Bengali folk music. Traditionally associated with boatmen travelling along the rivers of Bengal, the genre emerged within a geographical environment dominated by waterways. Rivers played an essential role in transportation, trade and communication, and they also shaped the emotional and artistic life of river communities.

The songs frequently express feelings of loneliness, longing, separation and reflection. Many lyrics use the river as a symbol for life's journey, uncertainty and the search for meaning. These themes are closely connected to the occupational experiences of the singers who originally performed them.

The melodic structure of Bhatiali reflects this emotional atmosphere. One of its most distinctive features is the use of long, flowing melodic lines. Instead of rapid note movement, the melodies often unfold gradually, allowing individual notes to be sustained for extended periods. This creates a sense of openness and spaciousness that mirrors the vast river landscape.

Another important characteristic is the frequent use of descending melodic movement. Many Bhatiali songs rise slowly towards a melodic peak before returning through a smooth and expressive descent. This descending motion often carries the emotional centre of the phrase and contributes significantly to the reflective quality of the genre.

Researchers and musicians have frequently noted similarities between Bhatiali melodies and Kafi-type modal structures. The presence of certain note combinations, particularly those

involving komal Ga and komal Ni, creates an environment that may remind listeners of Kafi and related ragas. However, Bhatiali performances generally allow a greater degree of flexibility than would be expected in a classical raga presentation.

For this reason, Bhatiali provides an excellent example of a folk tradition that shares modal features with classical music while maintaining its own distinct musical identity.

### **3.4 Bhawaiya Music**

Bhawaiya developed primarily in the northern regions of Bengal, particularly in areas associated with rural communities, agricultural activity and pastoral life. Historically, the genre became closely connected with the experiences of cart drivers, cattle herders and working people whose daily lives often involved travel, separation and emotional hardship.

The emotional character of Bhawaiya is one of its most striking features. Themes of longing, love, absence and personal suffering appear frequently within the lyrics. Consequently, musical expression occupies a central position within the performance tradition. The singer is expected not only to reproduce a melody but also to communicate the emotional content of the song effectively.

Musically, Bhawaiya is characterised by sustained notes, gradual melodic movement and expressive slides between pitches. Notes are often connected through smooth transitions rather than presented as separate units. This approach produces a flowing melodic texture that contributes to the emotional depth of the genre.

Many Bhawaiya melodies display characteristics that invite comparison with Bhairavi-type modal environments. Certain descending phrase patterns and note relationships resemble those found in Bhairavi and related ragas. Nevertheless, these similarities should not be interpreted as evidence of direct dependence upon classical grammar. The overall behaviour of Bhawaiya melodies remains strongly influenced by regional performance practice and oral tradition.

The genre therefore occupies an interesting position within the broader discussion of folk and classical interaction.

### **3.5 Kirtan Music**

Kirtan occupies a special place within Bengali devotional culture. The genre developed within the Vaishnava tradition and gained widespread popularity through the religious movement associated with Sri Chaitanya Mahaprabhu. Unlike many folk genres that emerged from

occupational or regional contexts, Kirtan developed primarily as a form of devotional expression.

The principal purpose of Kirtan is the collective singing of sacred texts and devotional poetry. As a result, participation and emotional engagement are often more important than technical complexity. The music serves as a vehicle for religious experience and communal worship.

At the same time, Kirtan demonstrates stronger interaction with classical musical traditions than many other forms of Bengali folk music. Certain compositions display organised melodic structures, identifiable modal tendencies and phrase patterns that resemble classical ragas. Similarities with Khamaj, Kafi and Desh are particularly noticeable in some examples.

Despite these connections, Kirtan continues to function according to its own priorities. Melodic decisions are frequently influenced by devotional requirements, congregational participation and textual meaning rather than by strict adherence to raga grammar.

This combination of folk accessibility and classical influence makes Kirtan especially important for understanding the relationship between the two traditions.

### **3.6 Comparative Overview**

Although Baul, Bhatiali, Bhawaiya and Kirtan all belong to the broader category of Bengali folk music, they represent very different musical environments. Baul music is shaped by spiritual philosophy and personal expression. Bhatiali reflects the river culture of Bengal and is characterised by long flowing melodies. Bhawaiya emphasises emotional intensity and regional vocal style, while Kirtan combines devotional practice with elements of classical musical organisation.

Despite these differences, all four genres display modal characteristics that invite comparison with Hindustani ragas. At the same time, each genre preserves distinctive features that cannot be fully explained through classical theory alone. These observations suggest that the relationship between folk music and raga music is more complex than simple derivation or imitation.

### **3.7 Conclusion**

The four genres discussed in this chapter illustrate the diversity and richness of Bengali folk music. Each tradition has developed within a specific historical and cultural environment, resulting in unique melodic structures and performance practices. While similarities with classical ragas can be identified in many cases, these genres continue to operate according to their own artistic principles. The discussion presented here provides the foundation for the

analytical work undertaken in the following chapters. By understanding the historical background and musical characteristics of these traditions, it becomes possible to examine their modal behaviour in a more systematic and meaningful way.

## **CHAPTER 4**

### **ANALYTICAL FRAMEWORK: COMPARING FOLK SCALES TO RAGAS**

#### **4.1 Introduction**

One of the main challenges in studying the relationship between Bengali folk music and Hindustani classical music is the question of comparison. Similarity between two melodies may appear obvious at first hearing, yet closer examination often reveals important differences.

Many folk songs are commonly described as being based on particular ragas. However, such statements are frequently made without detailed musical analysis. Since a raga consists of much more than a collection of notes, it is necessary to establish clear criteria before attempting any comparison.

This chapter develops the analytical framework used in the present study. The framework focuses on melodic behaviour, note relationships and modal organisation rather than relying only on scale similarity.

#### **4.2 Why Scale Similarity Alone Is Not Enough**

In Indian music, two melodies may use exactly the same notes while creating completely different musical identities.

For example, several ragas may share similar note collections but differ in:

- Characteristic phrases.
- Important notes.
- Ascending and descending movement.
- Ornamentation.
- Emotional expression.

Therefore, identifying a common scale does not automatically establish a direct relationship between a folk melody and a classical raga.

A meaningful comparison requires a deeper examination of musical behaviour.

This principle forms the foundation of the present study.

### **4.3 Understanding Modal Structure**

The term "modal structure" refers to the way notes are organised and used within a musical system.

In Western musicology, the concept of mode is often used to describe scales that possess characteristic melodic behaviour. A similar idea can be applied to Bengali folk music.

For the purpose of this study, modal structure includes:

- Selection of notes.
- Relative importance of notes.
- Typical melodic movements.
- Recurring phrase patterns.
- Cadential tendencies.

By focusing on these elements, it becomes possible to examine folk melodies without forcing them into a purely classical framework.

### **4.4 Elements Selected for Analysis**

The present study evaluates each folk melody according to five principal criteria.

#### **1. Scale Structure**

The first step is identifying the notes used within the melody.

Questions considered include:

- Which swaras appear regularly?
- Are any notes omitted?

- Are altered notes present?
- Does the scale resemble a recognised thaat?

Scale analysis provides an initial basis for comparison.

## 2. Melodic Movement

The second step examines how notes move within the melody.

Particular attention is given to:

- Ascending motion.
- Descending motion.
- Directional preference.
- Repeated note patterns.

A melody may share a scale with a raga while exhibiting very different movement patterns.

## 3. Note Emphasis

The analysis also investigates whether particular notes receive special importance.

Questions include:

- Which notes appear most frequently?
- Where do phrases begin?
- Where do phrases end?
- Are there notes that function similarly to vadi or samvadi?

The purpose is not to impose classical concepts on folk music but to identify possible structural parallels.

## 4. Characteristic Phrases

Many musical traditions develop recurring melodic phrases that contribute to identity.

In classical music, these phrases are often associated with pakad.

The study therefore examines:

- Frequently repeated patterns.
- Distinctive melodic gestures.
- Phrase endings.
- Phrase openings.

These observations help distinguish superficial similarities from deeper structural relationships.

### 5. Performance Practice

Although the study focuses primarily on melodic analysis, certain performance elements are also considered.

These include:

- Ornamentation.
- Vocal inflection.
- Flexible intonation.
- Regional stylistic features.

Performance practice often reveals aspects of musical identity that cannot be captured through notation alone.

### **4.5 Analytical Procedure**

The analytical process used in this study consists of five stages.

**Stage One:** Selection of representative folk songs.

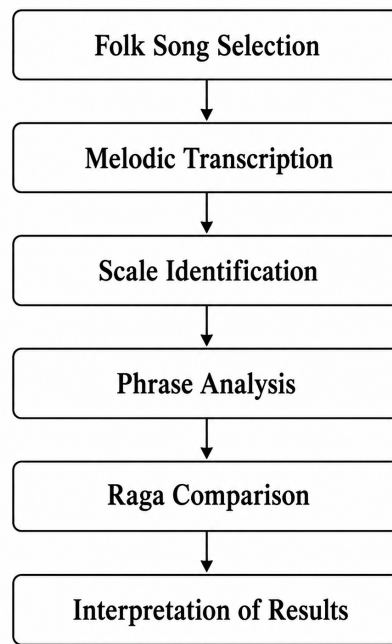
**Stage Two:** Transcription of important melodic passages using Bhatkhande notation.

**Stage Three:** Identification of scales and note collections.

**Stage Four:** Comparison with relevant Hindustani ragas.

**Stage Five:** Evaluation of similarities and differences.

This procedure allows each comparison to follow a consistent method.

**Figure 4.1 (Analytical Procedure Used in the Study)**

#### 4.6 Criteria for Raga Comparison

To maintain consistency, each folk melody will be evaluated according to the following criteria.

**Table 4.1 Comparison Criteria**

| Criterion              | Questions Asked                           |
|------------------------|-------------------------------------------|
| Scale Structure        | Which notes are used?                     |
| Melodic Movement       | How does the melody travel?               |
| Note Emphasis          | Are certain notes more important?         |
| Characteristic Phrases | Do recurring patterns exist?              |
| Overall Behaviour      | Does the melody follow raga-like grammar? |

The final interpretation will be based on all criteria rather than a single feature.

#### 4.7 Raga Grammar and Folk Flexibility

One important difference between classical and folk traditions lies in the degree of flexibility allowed during performance.

Classical ragas generally operate within recognised grammatical boundaries.

These may include:

- Prescribed note usage.
- Characteristic phrases.
- Rules regarding ascent and descent.
- Traditional performance conventions.

Folk music often functions differently.

A singer may alter phrases according to:

- Local tradition.
- Personal style.
- Emotional expression.
- Practical performance situations.

As a result, a folk melody may display raga-like characteristics without fully conforming to raga grammar.

Recognising this distinction is essential for a balanced analysis.

#### **4.8 Working Classification Used in the Study**

To simplify interpretation, the study adopts three broad categories.

### **Category I**

Raga-Derived Folk Modes

These melodies display strong similarity to a recognised raga and retain many of its structural characteristics.

### **Category II**

Hybrid Modal Forms

These melodies combine features associated with more than one modal tradition.

## Category III

### Independent Folk Modes

These melodies possess distinctive behaviour that cannot be adequately explained through existing raga frameworks.

This classification serves as a practical analytical tool rather than a rigid theoretical system.

### 4.9 Limitations of the Method

Every analytical framework has limitations.

The present study acknowledges several challenges.

First, folk traditions are transmitted orally, which often results in multiple versions of the same song.

Second, performance styles vary among singers and regions.

Third, historical evidence regarding the origins of particular melodies is often incomplete.

For these reasons, the study does not attempt to provide definitive historical conclusions. Instead, it focuses on observable musical characteristics.

### 4.10 Conclusion

This chapter has established the analytical framework used throughout the study. By examining scale structure, melodic movement, note emphasis, characteristic phrases and performance practice, the research aims to provide a more balanced understanding of the relationship between Bengali folk music and Hindustani ragas.

The framework recognises both similarity and difference. Rather than assuming that folk melodies are simply simplified ragas, it allows them to be evaluated according to their own musical behaviour.

The next chapter applies this framework to selected musical examples from Baul, Bhatiali, Bhawaiya and Kirtan traditions.

## CHAPTER 5

### CASE STUDIES: MODAL STRUCTURES IN SELECTED BENGALI FOLK GENRES

#### 5.1 Introduction

The central objective of this study is to examine whether selected Bengali folk traditions follow the grammatical principles associated with Hindustani ragas or whether they operate according to their own modal systems. The previous chapters discussed the historical background of Bengali folk music, the development of raga theory and the analytical framework adopted for this research. This chapter applies that framework to selected musical traditions in order to investigate their melodic behaviour in detail.

The genres selected for analysis are Bhatiali, Baul, Bhawaiya and Kirtan. These traditions were chosen because of their historical importance within Bengali musical culture and because they represent different social, geographical and religious environments. Although all four traditions belong to the broader category of Bengali folk music, their melodic structures reveal significant differences.

The purpose of the present analysis is not to prove that a folk song is identical to a classical raga. Such an approach would oversimplify the nature of folk music. Instead, the objective is to identify areas of resemblance and difference. The study focuses on scale structure, melodic movement, note emphasis, phrase organisation and performance practice.

Since folk music is transmitted through oral tradition, different versions of the same song may exist. Consequently, the analysis concentrates on representative melodic tendencies rather than claiming a single definitive version.

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#### 5.2 CASE STUDY I BHATIALI AND KAFI-TYPE MODAL BEHAVIOUR

##### 5.2.1 Historical Background

Among the various folk traditions of Bengal, Bhatiali occupies a special place because of its close relationship with the riverine environment of the region. The extensive river networks of

Bengal shaped not only transportation and economic activity but also the emotional and artistic life of local communities. Boatmen travelling across long stretches of water often spent many hours in relative isolation. Music became a means of expression, communication and emotional release.

The word "Bhatiali" is generally associated with the downstream movement of boats. The songs are characterised by a reflective and often melancholic mood. Themes of separation, longing, memory and the uncertainty of life frequently appear in the lyrics. These emotional qualities are reflected in the musical structure of the genre.

Unlike highly organised classical performances, Bhatiali songs are generally built around broad melodic contours rather than strict grammatical rules. Nevertheless, certain recurring modal characteristics can be identified.

### **5.2.2 General Melodic Characteristics**

One of the most noticeable features of Bhatiali music is the use of long sustained notes. Instead of rapid melodic movement, the singer often remains on a single note for an extended period before gradually moving to another pitch. This creates a feeling of openness and distance which reflects the physical environment in which the songs developed.

Another important characteristic is the preference for descending melodic movement. Many Bhatiali melodies rise gradually toward a high point before returning through a smooth descending line. The descent frequently carries the emotional weight of the phrase.

The melodic range is usually moderate to wide. Singers often begin in the middle register and gradually expand toward the upper octave. Large leaps are generally avoided, and continuity of movement is preferred.

### **5.2.3 Representative Musical Example 5.1**

Illustrative Phrase:

S R g m P

P m g R S

### **Musical Analysis**

The phrase begins with a straightforward ascending movement from the tonic towards Pancham. There are no abrupt jumps or angular transitions. The melodic line unfolds gradually, creating a sense of expansion. The return from Pancham to Sa follows a smooth descending contour.

The use of komal Ga immediately creates a modal environment that resembles the Kafi family of ragas. However, unlike a classical Kafi presentation, the phrase does not emphasise a clearly identifiable pakad. The movement appears more concerned with maintaining melodic continuity than with demonstrating raga grammar.

The phrase also illustrates the importance of descent within Bhatiali music. Although the ascent establishes the melodic space, the emotional resolution occurs during the return movement.

#### **5.2.4 Representative Musical Example 5.2**

Illustrative Phrase:

m P D n S'

m D P m

g R S

#### **Musical Analysis**

This phrase demonstrates the tendency of Bhatiali melodies to move towards the upper register before descending gradually to the tonic. The upper Sa functions as a temporary point of arrival rather than a permanent resting note.

Particular attention may be given to the descent from Nishad through Dhaivat and Pancham. In many performances this section is rendered through a gentle meend rather than through sharply separated notes.

From a performer's perspective, especially on the violin, the phrase becomes significantly more expressive when executed through continuous bow movement. The melodic effect depends not only on the notes themselves but also on the quality of transition between them.

#### **5.2.5 Representative Musical Example 5.3**

Illustrative Phrase:

S R m P

D P m

g R S

## Musical Analysis

The omission of certain intermediary notes in this phrase produces a simplified contour that remains common in many folk melodies. While classical ragas often rely on highly specific phrase structures, folk music frequently achieves expression through directness and clarity.

The phrase creates a strong feeling of return. After reaching Dhaivat, the melody immediately begins its descent. The listener's attention is directed toward the lower register where the phrase finally settles on the tonic.

Such movements support the view that Bhatiali is organised around broad modal tendencies rather than rigid melodic prescriptions.

### 5.2.6 Comparison with Raga Kafi

**Table 5.1 Comparison between Bhatiali and Raga Kafi**

| Feature             | Bhatiali                                  | Raga Kafi                      |
|---------------------|-------------------------------------------|--------------------------------|
| Scale Material      | Frequently includes komal Ga and komal Ni | Includes komal Ga and komal Ni |
| Melodic Direction   | Strong descending tendency                | Balanced ascent and descent    |
| Pakad               | Flexible                                  | Clearly defined                |
| Improvisation       | Limited                                   | Extensive                      |
| Performance Context | Folk and occupational                     | Classical concert tradition    |

The strongest similarity between Bhatiali and Kafi lies in the note material employed by both traditions. However, the manner in which those notes are organised differs considerably.

Classical Kafi relies upon recognised phrase structures that help establish the identity of the raga. Bhatiali, on the other hand, allows much greater melodic freedom. Individual singers often shape phrases according to the demands of the lyrics and emotional content of the song.

For this reason, it would be inaccurate to describe Bhatiali simply as a folk version of Kafi. The relationship is better understood as a shared modal environment rather than a direct equivalence.

### **5.2.7 Interim Conclusion**

The analysis suggests that Bhatiali demonstrates a strong modal affinity with Kafi-type structures. Similarities are visible in scale organisation and certain phrase movements. Nevertheless, the overall behaviour of the genre differs from classical raga performance.

The evidence indicates that Bhatiali possesses its own musical identity while simultaneously sharing characteristics with broader North Indian modal traditions. This observation supports the argument that Bengali folk music should not be understood solely through the framework of classical raga theory.

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## **5.3 CASE STUDY II**

### **BAUL AND PILU-TYPE MODAL BEHAVIOUR**

#### **5.3.1 Historical Background**

Baul music occupies a unique position within Bengali culture. Unlike many folk genres that emerged from specific occupations or geographical conditions, Baul music developed within a spiritual and philosophical tradition. The Bauls sought direct personal experience of the divine rather than adherence to formal religious institutions. Their songs became an important vehicle for expressing these ideas.

Because the primary purpose of Baul music is communication of philosophical insight, melodic structure often remains closely connected to textual meaning. The singer adjusts tempo, ornamentation and pitch emphasis according to the emotional content of the lyrics.

This flexibility distinguishes Baul music from many forms of classical performance where the preservation of raga identity is a primary concern.

#### **5.3.2 General Melodic Characteristics**

Baul melodies frequently display a combination of simplicity and flexibility. The basic phrase structure may appear straightforward, yet performers often introduce subtle modifications during repetition.

Unlike Bhatiali, which emphasises broad melodic arcs, Baul songs often revolve around short recurring phrases. These phrases function almost like musical reflections of the philosophical ideas contained in the lyrics.

Another important feature is modal fluidity. Certain Baul melodies appear capable of moving between different modal areas without losing their identity. This characteristic makes direct classification within a single raga framework difficult.

### 5.3.3 Representative Musical Example 5.4

Illustrative Phrase:

S g M P

M g R

S

#### Musical Analysis

The phrase revolves around a compact melodic space. Rather than expanding towards the upper register, it repeatedly returns to the middle range.

The movement between Gandhar and Madhyam provides the central emotional character of the phrase. The repetition of these notes creates a feeling of contemplation, which is consistent with the philosophical nature of Baul poetry.

In comparison with Pilu, the phrase demonstrates a similar flexibility of note usage. However, its purpose is expressive rather than grammatical.

### 5.3.4 Representative Musical Example 5.5

Illustrative Phrase:

S G M P

D N S'

N D P

M G R S

## Musical Analysis

This phrase demonstrates the ability of Baul melodies to expand into the upper register while maintaining a sense of simplicity. The ascent towards the higher tonic is gradual and natural, without the elaborate phrase structures commonly associated with classical raga performance.

The descent is equally important. Rather than treating the upper tonic as the final destination, the melody uses it as a temporary point of emphasis before returning to the middle register. This movement reflects a recurring feature of Baul music, where melodic development often mirrors the reflective nature of the lyrics.

The phrase shares certain characteristics with Pilu because of its flexible treatment of note relationships. However, the musical purpose differs significantly. In classical music, phrase construction serves the preservation of raga identity. In Baul music, phrase construction primarily serves the expression of spiritual and emotional ideas.

### 5.3.5 Representative Musical Example 5.6

Illustrative Phrase:

M P D

P M G

R S

R G M

## Musical Analysis

This phrase illustrates the cyclical quality often found in Baul songs. Instead of progressing continuously in one direction, the melody repeatedly returns to familiar pitch areas.

The repeated movement between Madhyam and Pancham creates a feeling of stability. This stability provides a foundation upon which the singer can introduce subtle variations in ornamentation and rhythm.

From a modal perspective, the phrase demonstrates flexibility rather than strict adherence to a predefined structure. This characteristic supports the argument that Baul music operates within a modal framework that is related to but distinct from classical ragas.

### 5.3.6 Comparison with Pilu

**Table 5.2 Comparison between Baul and Pilu**

| Feature                 | Baul        | Raag Pilu   |
|-------------------------|-------------|-------------|
| Scale Flexibility       | Very High   | High        |
| Fixed Phrase Grammar    | Limited     | Moderate    |
| Improvisational Freedom | High        | High        |
| Emphasis on Lyrics      | Very Strong | Moderate    |
| Modal Stability         | Variable    | More Stable |

The relationship between Baul and Pilu is particularly interesting because both traditions allow a degree of flexibility not always present in more strictly defined ragas.

However, the source of that flexibility differs. In Pilu, flexibility exists within an established classical framework. In Baul music, flexibility emerges from oral transmission, personal expression and philosophical content.

As a result, similarities between Baul and Pilu should be interpreted as evidence of modal overlap rather than direct equivalence.

### 5.3.7 Interim Conclusion

The analysis suggests that Baul music shares several characteristics with Pilu-type modal structures, particularly in its flexible treatment of notes and its avoidance of rigid phrase patterns. Nevertheless, the genre maintains its own identity through its strong connection to lyrical meaning and spiritual expression.

---

## 5.4 CASE STUDY III

### BHAWAIYA AND BHAIRAVI-TYPE MODAL BEHAVIOUR

#### 5.4.1 Historical Background

Bhawaiya developed in the northern regions of Bengal, especially in areas associated with agricultural communities, bullock-cart drivers and pastoral life. The songs frequently explore themes of separation, longing and emotional uncertainty.

Unlike Bhatiali, whose imagery is shaped by rivers, Bhawaiya reflects the experience of travel across open land. The emotional atmosphere of the genre is often more intense and personal.

Many scholars have noted similarities between Bhawaiya and certain Bhairavi-related melodic structures. These similarities make Bhawaiya particularly suitable for modal comparison.

### **5.4.2 General Melodic Characteristics**

Bhawaiya melodies frequently employ elongated notes, expressive slides and emotionally charged phrase endings.

One of the defining characteristics of the genre is the strong emotional emphasis placed on particular notes. The singer often lingers on a pitch before moving slowly towards the next melodic destination.

The resulting musical effect is one of tension and release.

### **5.4.3 Representative Musical Example 5.7**

Illustrative Phrase:

S r g m

P d n S'

### **Musical Analysis**

This phrase gradually ascends through the scale while maintaining a sense of restraint. Unlike some classical ragas that employ highly developed ascending patterns, the movement here remains direct and emotionally focused.

The use of komal intervals contributes to the melancholic quality of the phrase. The emotional impact depends not only on the choice of notes but also on the way those notes are approached and sustained.

### **5.4.4 Representative Musical Example 5.8**

Illustrative Phrase:

S' n d P

m g r S

### **Musical Analysis**

The descending movement is particularly important in this example. The phrase creates a sense of emotional resolution through gradual return to the tonic.

The descent is often performed with subtle slides between notes, producing a continuity that is difficult to represent fully through notation alone.

When reproduced on a violin, these slides become especially important because they contribute significantly to the expressive quality of the melody.

#### **5.4.5 Representative Musical Example 5.9**

Illustrative Phrase:

g m P

d P m

g r S

### **Musical Analysis**

The phrase centres around Pancham before gradually returning towards the tonic. The repeated use of descending motion reinforces the emotional character of the genre.

Although the phrase may remind listeners of Bhairavi-related movements, it lacks the systematic phrase grammar expected in a classical Bhairavi performance.

This distinction highlights the importance of examining musical behaviour rather than relying solely on note collections.

#### **5.4.6 Comparison with Bhairavi**

**Table 5.3 Comparison between Bhawaiya and Bhairavi**

| <b>Feature</b> | <b>Bhawaiya</b> | <b>Raga Bhairavi</b> |
|----------------|-----------------|----------------------|
| Komal Swaras   | Common          | Common               |

| Feature                     | Bhawaiya | Raga Bhairavi |
|-----------------------------|----------|---------------|
| Descending Motion           | Strong   | Strong        |
| Fixed Pakad                 | Limited  | Present       |
| Improvisational Development | Limited  | Extensive     |
| Performance Context         | Folk     | Classical     |

The comparison demonstrates that Bhawaiya and Bhairavi share certain modal characteristics. However, the organisational principles of the two traditions remain distinct.

Bhairavi functions within a well-developed classical framework, whereas Bhawaiya prioritises emotional communication and regional performance practice.

#### **5.4.7 Interim Conclusion**

The evidence suggests that Bhawaiya occupies a position between folk modality and Bhairavi-type melodic organisation. Similarities are significant but not sufficient to classify the genre as a direct derivative of the raga.

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### **5.5 CASE STUDY IV**

#### **KIRTAN AND KHAMAJ–KAFI INFLUENCE**

##### **5.5.1 Historical Background**

Among the genres examined in this study, Kirtan displays the strongest historical connection with organised musical practice. The tradition developed within the devotional environment of the Vaishnava movement and gradually evolved into a sophisticated musical form.

Unlike many folk genres, Kirtan frequently incorporates elements associated with both classical and semi-classical music. This makes it particularly valuable for investigating the interaction between folk and classical traditions.

##### **5.5.2 General Melodic Characteristics**

Kirtan melodies often combine devotional simplicity with structural sophistication.

The genre relies heavily on repetition because congregational participation forms an essential part of performance practice.

At the same time, many Kirtan melodies reveal phrase structures and note relationships that suggest interaction with established raga traditions.

### **5.5.3 Representative Musical Example 5.10**

Illustrative Phrase:

S R G m

P D N S'

#### **Musical Analysis**

The phrase establishes a bright and open modal environment. The ascent is clear and direct, making it suitable for collective singing.

Unlike certain folk genres that emphasise modal ambiguity, Kirtan often benefits from clarity because large groups of participants must follow the melody simultaneously.

### **5.5.4 Representative Musical Example 5.11**

Illustrative Phrase:

S' n D P

m G R S

#### **Musical Analysis**

The descending movement provides balance and closure. The phrase demonstrates a degree of structural organisation that is closer to classical practice than many other folk traditions.

Nevertheless, the primary objective remains devotional expression rather than formal raga presentation.

### **5.5.5 Representative Musical Example 5.12**

Illustrative Phrase:

G m P

G m P  
D P m G  
R S

**Musical Analysis**

This repeated phrase structure illustrates the importance of participation within Kirtan. Repetition reinforces both musical memory and devotional engagement.

The phrase demonstrates how relatively simple melodic material can produce a powerful collective musical experience.

**5.5.6 Comparison with Khamaj and Kafi**

**Table 5.4 Comparison between Kirtan and Khamaj/Kafi**

Feature | Kirtan | Khamaj/Kafi  
Classical Influence | High | High  
Devotional Function | Central | Variable  
Phrase Repetition | Strong | Moderate  
Improvisation | Limited | Extensive  
Modal Stability | High | High

| Feature             | Kirtan  | Raag Khamaj / Kafi |
|---------------------|---------|--------------------|
| Classical Influence | High    | High               |
| Devotional Function | Central | Variable           |
| Phrase Repetition   | Strong  | Moderate           |
| Improvisation       | Limited | Extensive          |
| Modal Stability     | High    | High               |

Among the four genres studied, Kirtan displays the strongest evidence of interaction with classical musical traditions. Nevertheless, its devotional purpose continues to distinguish it from concert-oriented raga performance.

5.5.7 Interim Conclusion

The analysis suggests that Kirtan represents a particularly important meeting point between folk and classical traditions. While many melodic features resemble Khamaj and Kafi-related structures, devotional function remains the dominant organising principle.

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5.6 COMPARATIVE MODAL ANALYSIS

Having examined the four genres individually, it becomes possible to compare them collectively.

Table 5.5 Comparative Modal Characteristics

| Genre    | Closest Modal Association | Scale Flexibility | Classical Influence |
|----------|---------------------------|-------------------|---------------------|
| Bhatiali | Kafi                      | Moderate          | Moderate            |
| Baul     | Pilu                      | High              | Moderate            |
| Bhawaiya | Bhairavi-Type             | Moderate          | Moderate            |
| Kirtan   | Khamaj/Kafi               | Moderate          | High                |

Table 5.6 Estimated Modal Similarity

| Genre    | Associated Raga | Similarity Estimate |
|----------|-----------------|---------------------|
| Bhatiali | Kafi            | High                |
| Baul     | Pilu            | Moderate-High       |
| Bhawaiya | Bhairavi-Type   | Moderate-High       |
| Kirtan   | Khamaj/Kafi     | High                |

The comparison reveals that no genre demonstrates complete correspondence with any single raga. Similarities certainly exist, yet important differences remain visible.

These findings support the argument that Bengali folk music should be understood as a collection of modal traditions rather than as simplified versions of classical ragas.

## 5.7 DISCUSSION

The analysis presented in this chapter suggests that the relationship between Bengali folk music and Hindustani classical music is best understood as a process of interaction rather than direct derivation.

The first extreme position claims that folk music developed entirely from classical ragas. The second claims that folk music evolved independently without meaningful connection to classical traditions.

The evidence examined in this study supports neither extreme.

Instead, the findings indicate a more complex relationship. Bengali folk traditions share certain modal resources with classical music while simultaneously preserving their own organisational principles.

This dual character explains why listeners often recognise similarities between folk songs and ragas while still perceiving them as distinct musical experiences.

## 5.8 CONCLUSION

The case studies presented in this chapter demonstrate that Bengali folk music contains rich and sophisticated modal structures. Similarities with Hindustani ragas are visible in scale organisation, note selection and certain phrase movements. At the same time, important differences emerge in performance practice, phrase construction and melodic flexibility.

The evidence therefore suggests that Bengali folk genres should not be treated merely as simplified forms of classical music. Rather, they represent independent musical traditions that have evolved through continuous interaction with broader North Indian modal culture.

These findings provide the foundation for the next chapter, which proposes a theoretical framework for understanding Bengali folk modal structures and their relationship to the classical raga system.

# CHAPTER 6

## TOWARDS A BENGALI FOLK MODAL FRAMEWORK: INTERPRETATION, THEORY AND CONCLUSION

### 6.1 Introduction

The analyses presented in the previous chapter revealed a recurring pattern. Although the selected Bengali folk genres display noticeable similarities with Hindustani ragas, none of them conforms completely to classical raga grammar. In every case, similarities and differences coexist.

Bhatiali shares modal features with Kafi, yet its melodic organisation remains considerably more flexible. Baul music demonstrates modal behaviour that occasionally resembles Pilu, but its structure is shaped primarily by philosophical expression rather than by raga rules. Bhawaiya exhibits melodic tendencies comparable to Bhairavi-type environments, yet follows its own regional performance practices. Kirtan displays perhaps the strongest interaction with classical music, but even here devotional function often takes precedence over strict adherence to raga grammar.

These observations raise an important question. If Bengali folk music cannot be fully explained through existing raga theory, how should its modal behaviour be understood?

The present chapter attempts to answer that question by proposing a practical framework for interpreting Bengali folk modal structures.

### 6.2 Reconsidering the Folk–Classical Relationship

Throughout the history of Indian music, the relationship between folk and classical traditions has often been described in simple terms. One common view suggests that folk music is merely an informal version of classical music. Another argues that folk traditions developed independently and should be studied separately from classical systems.

The findings of this study suggest that both positions are incomplete.

The modal similarities identified in Chapter Five cannot be ignored. Certain note combinations, phrase movements and melodic tendencies clearly overlap with recognised ragas. At the same time, the organisational principles of Bengali folk music differ significantly from those of classical performance.

This suggests that the relationship between the two traditions is not one of direct dependence. Instead, it may be understood as a process of continuous interaction.

Over many centuries, folk traditions and classical traditions appear to have shared melodic material, influenced one another and developed alongside one another. In some cases, folk melodies may have contributed to the development of classical ragas. In other cases, classical influences may have entered folk performance through devotional movements, travelling musicians and cultural exchange.

Rather than viewing one tradition as superior or more authentic than the other, it is more productive to view them as interconnected branches of a broader musical culture.

### **6.3 The Need for an Alternative Analytical Framework**

The analysis undertaken in this dissertation has demonstrated several limitations of relying exclusively on classical raga theory when studying folk music.

For example, many folk melodies:

- Do not maintain a fixed aroha and avaroha.
- Do not consistently establish identifiable vadi and samvadi relationships.
- Frequently allow greater phrase variation.
- Adapt melodic movement according to textual and emotional requirements.
- Permit local performance practices that would be unusual in formal classical contexts.

When such melodies are analysed solely according to classical criteria, important aspects of their musical identity may be overlooked.

This does not mean that raga theory is irrelevant. On the contrary, classical theory remains an extremely useful analytical tool. However, it should not be the only framework through which folk traditions are understood.

A more flexible approach is therefore necessary.

### **6.4 The Bengali Folk Modal Framework (BFMF)**

Based on the findings of this study, the following framework is proposed as a practical method for understanding Bengali folk modal behaviour.

The framework does not attempt to replace classical music theory. Instead, it provides an additional perspective specifically designed for folk traditions.

The Bengali Folk Modal Framework (BFMF) consists of three broad categories.

## **CATEGORY I**

### **Strong Raga Correspondence**

This category includes folk melodies that display substantial similarity to recognised ragas.

Characteristics include:

- Stable scale organisation.
- Consistent note usage.
- Strong resemblance to recognised modal structures.
- Frequent overlap with classical melodic material.

Examples identified in this study include certain Bhatiali and Kirtan melodies.

Although these songs remain part of folk tradition, their modal organisation frequently approaches classical practice.

## **CATEGORY II**

### **Hybrid Modal Behaviour**

This category includes melodies that combine features from multiple modal environments.

Characteristics include:

- Flexible note usage.
- Mixed modal tendencies.
- Frequent phrase variation.
- Context-dependent melodic movement.

Baul music often demonstrates these characteristics.

The melodic identity of these songs emerges not from a single scale structure but from a combination of modal influences shaped by performance context.

## Category III

### Independent Folk Modal Behaviour

This category includes melodies whose identity depends primarily on regional performance practice rather than correspondence with recognised ragas.

Characteristics include:

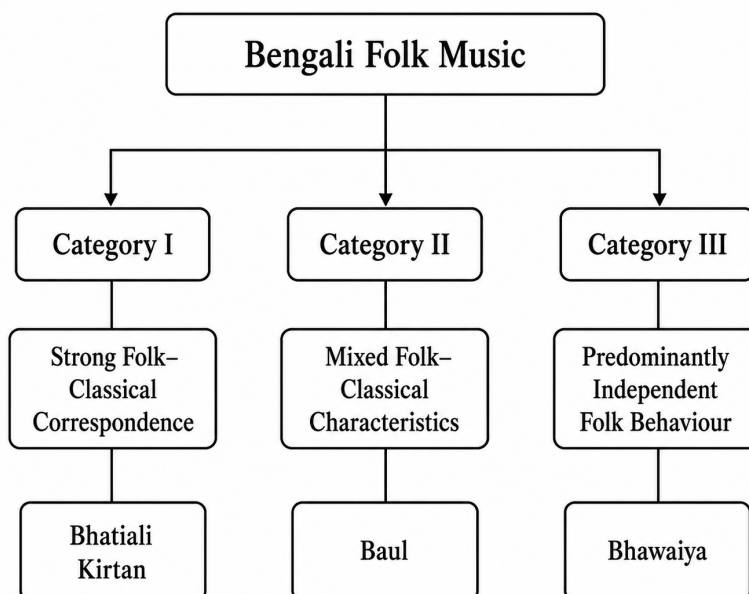
- Strong local stylistic features.
- Flexible phrase organisation.
- Distinctive ornamentation.
- Limited dependence on classical frameworks.

Certain Bhawaiya traditions provide examples of this category.

Although similarities with classical ragas may exist, the overall behaviour of the melody is best understood within its own regional context.

## 6.5 Visual Representation of the Framework

**Figure 6.1 [Bengali Folk Modal Framework (BFMF)]**

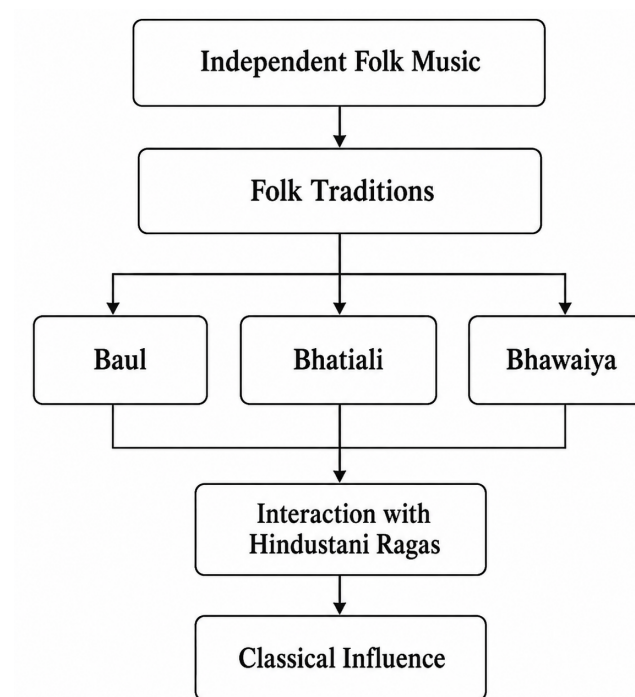


The purpose of this model is not rigid classification. Instead, it serves as a guide for understanding different degrees of interaction between folk and classical traditions.

## 6.6 Implications for Musicology

The findings of this study have several implications for Indian musicology.

**Figure 6.2 (Relationship Between Bengali Folk Music and Classical Influence)**



First, they suggest that folk music deserves analysis as a sophisticated musical system rather than merely as a cultural artifact.

Second, they demonstrate that modal thinking exists outside formal classical traditions. Even where no written theory exists, performers often preserve highly consistent melodic practices through oral transmission.

Third, the study highlights the value of examining performance practice alongside theoretical structures. In many cases, the identity of a folk melody depends as much on its delivery as on its scale.

Finally, the research encourages a more balanced understanding of the relationship between folk and classical music. Instead of viewing one tradition as a simplified version of the other, both

should be recognised as important contributors to the musical heritage of the Indian subcontinent.

### **6.7 Implications for Performers**

The findings are also relevant for performers, particularly instrumentalists.

As a student of instrumental music, one quickly discovers that folk melodies often demand a different approach from classical compositions. The performer must pay close attention not only to pitch but also to phrasing, timing and expressive nuance.

For violinists especially, Bengali folk music offers valuable opportunities to explore meend, subtle pitch variation and sustained melodic expression.

A technically accurate performance may still fail to capture the character of a folk melody if it ignores these expressive elements.

This observation reinforces the idea that folk music should be studied as a complete musical practice rather than simply as a collection of notes.

### **6.8 Limitations of the Study**

The present research also has certain limitations.

First, the study focuses on a limited number of genres and representative examples. The diversity of Bengali folk music extends far beyond the traditions examined here.

Second, the analysis relies primarily on available documented material. A larger body of field recordings would allow more extensive comparison.

Third, oral traditions naturally produce multiple versions of the same song. As a result, no single analysis can fully represent every performance practice.

These limitations should be considered when interpreting the findings.

### **6.9 Suggestions for Future Research**

The present study opens several possibilities for future investigation. Future researchers may:

- Conduct fieldwork with folk performers in different regions.
- Compare Bengali folk traditions with folk music from Assam, Odisha and Bangladesh.
- Use acoustic software to study microtonal variation.
- Investigate the role of instruments such as the dotara, ektara and violin in modal development.
- Examine additional genres that were beyond the scope of this study.

Such research would contribute to a more comprehensive understanding of regional musical systems.

## 6.10 Final Conclusion

The objective of this dissertation was to examine whether selected Bengali folk traditions follow the grammatical principles of Hindustani ragas or whether they operate according to independent modal systems.

The analysis revealed that Bengali folk music occupies a position between these two possibilities.

The selected genres share meaningful similarities with classical ragas in terms of scale organisation and certain melodic tendencies. However, they do not consistently follow the complete grammatical structures that define classical raga performance.

Instead, Bengali folk music demonstrates a flexible modal logic shaped by oral transmission, regional culture, performance practice and emotional expression.

The evidence therefore supports the view that Bengali folk music should be understood as a modal tradition in its own right. Its relationship with classical music is significant, but that relationship is one of interaction rather than complete dependence.

By proposing the Bengali Folk Modal Framework, this study offers a practical way of understanding these relationships while recognising the unique identity of Bengali folk traditions.

The continuing dialogue between folk and classical music remains one of the most fascinating aspects of Indian musical culture. Understanding that dialogue not only enriches musicological research but also deepens appreciation for the diversity and creativity of Bengal's musical heritage.

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## **APPENDIX A**

## ILLUSTRATIVE BHATKHANDI NOTATION EXAMPLES

### Note to the Reader

The following examples are included as illustrative analytical material designed to demonstrate representative modal tendencies discussed in the dissertation. As Bengali folk traditions are transmitted primarily through oral practice and frequently exist in multiple performance variants, the examples should be understood as analytical representations rather than definitive transcriptions of any single performance.

#### Example A.1

##### Representative Bhatiali-Type Phrase

S R g m P

P m g R S

##### Observation:

The phrase demonstrates a gradual ascent followed by a smooth descending resolution. The prominence of komal Ga contributes to a modal environment resembling Kafi-type structures.

---

#### Example A.2

##### Representative Baul-Type Phrase

S g m P

m g R S

##### Observation:

The phrase remains within a relatively compact melodic range. Repetition and flexibility are more important than strict modal definition.

---

#### Example A.3

### **Representative Bhawaiya-Type Phrase**

S r g m  
 P d n S'  
 S' n d P  
 m g r S

#### **Observation:**

The emotional character of the phrase emerges primarily through descending motion and sustained note treatment.

---

### **Example A.4**

#### **Representative Kirtan-Type Phrase**

S R G M  
 P D N S'  
  
 S' N D P  
 M G R S

#### **Observation:**

The phrase demonstrates greater structural stability and stronger resemblance to organised modal practice.

APPENDIX B

COMPARATIVE MODAL ANALYSIS TABLES

Table B.1 Comparison of Melodic Characteristics

|          |                 |                   |                   |                   |
|----------|-----------------|-------------------|-------------------|-------------------|
| Genre    | Sustained Notes | Descending Motion | Phrase Repetition | Modal Flexibility |
| Bhatiali | High            | Very High         | Moderate          | Moderate          |
| Baul     | Moderate        | Moderate          | High              | Very High         |
| Bhawaiya | High            | High              | Moderate          | Moderate          |
| Kirtan   | Moderate        | Moderate          | High              | Moderate          |

Table B.2 Relationship with Classical Modal Systems

|          |                           |                      |
|----------|---------------------------|----------------------|
| Genre    | Primary Modal Association | Degree of Similarity |
| Bhatiali | Kafi                      | High                 |
| Baul     | Pilu                      | Moderate–High        |
| Bhawaiya | Bhairavi-Type             | Moderate–High        |
| Kirtan   | Khamaj/Kafi               | High                 |

Table B.3 Performance Priorities

|          |                          |
|----------|--------------------------|
| Genre    | Main Musical Priority    |
| Bhatiali | Emotional Reflection     |
| Baul     | Spiritual Expression     |
| Bhawaiya | Emotional Communication  |
| Kirtan   | Devotional Participation |

Table B.4 Modal Classification According to BFMF

|          |               |
|----------|---------------|
| Genre    | BFMF Category |
| Bhatiali | Category I    |
| Baul     | Category II   |
| Bhawaiya | Category III  |
| Kirtan   | Category I    |

## **APPENDIX C**

### **SUMMARY OF THE ANALYTICAL FRAMEWORK**

The analytical framework adopted in this dissertation consists of five principal stages.

#### **Stage 1: Selection of Representative Material**

Representative examples from Baul, Bhatiali, Bhawaiya and Kirtan traditions were selected based on their historical importance and relevance to the research objectives.

#### **Stage 2: Identification of Modal Characteristics**

Each example was examined with regard to note selection, scale tendencies and melodic organisation.

#### **Stage 3: Phrase-Level Analysis**

Characteristic melodic movements, phrase structures and directional tendencies were identified.

#### **Stage 4: Comparison with Hindustani Ragas**

The selected examples were compared with established raga structures in order to identify areas of similarity and difference.

#### **Stage 5: Interpretation**

The findings were interpreted within a broader musicological framework that recognised both the individuality of folk traditions and their relationship with classical modal systems.

This procedure formed the basis of the Bengali Folk Modal Framework (BFMF) proposed in Chapter Six.